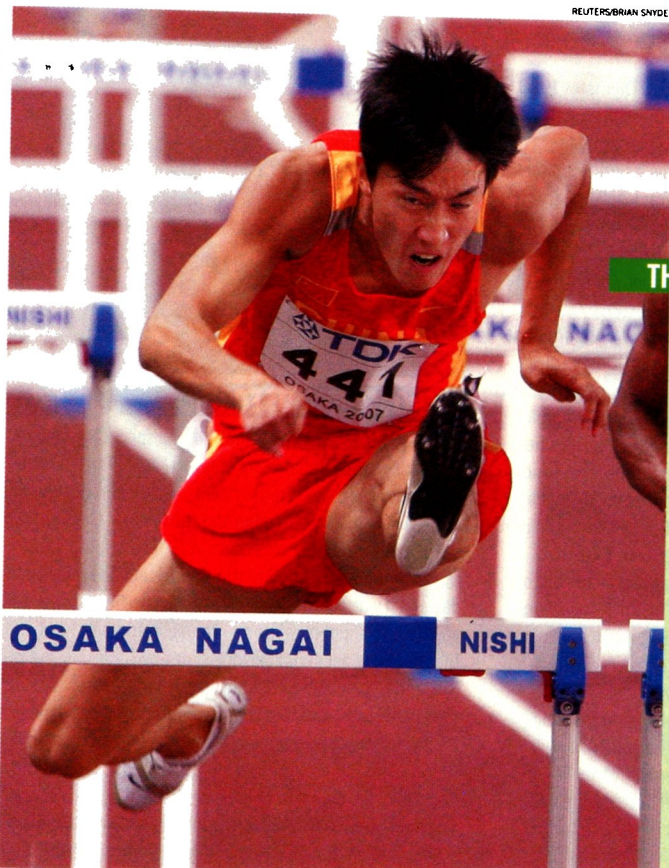


ESTIMATES OF RELOCATIONS IN THE RUN-UP TO THE GAMES VARY FROM THE GOVERNMENT'S OFFICIAL FIGURE OF 6,037 FAMILIES TO AS MANY AS FIVE LAKH.



THE DRAGON'S MARCH

China participated in two Olympics before WW II and then withdrew from the Olympic movement in 1958 in protest against the status given to Taiwan, only returning to participate in the 1984 Olympics in Los Angeles. Here is their rise:

1984 LA: 15 gold, 8 silver, 9 bronze = 4th on the table (based on gold)

1988 Seoul: 5 g, 11 s, 12 b = 11th

1992 Barcelona: 16 g, 22 s, 16 b = 4th

1996 Atlanta: 16 g, 22 s, 12 b = 4th

2000 Sydney: 28 g, 16 s, 15 b = 3rd

2004 Athens: 32 g, 17 s, 14 b = 2nd

Du Li begged, "Please don't hype it up." Even the stoic Liu was quoted as saying of the Games, "I will try my best but I still have to live after this..." Phelps, too, has struggled with waiting, "The last three weeks seem like forever." He has spent the time between training playing cards and trying not to watch the clock.

Never mind humanity, the Olympics certainly unite athletes—in the desperate anticipation, in the appetite for action. India's boxers were left straining to visit their competition venue, the Workers Stadium, for the lack of a bus. They trained in a downtown Beijing gym, skipping rope to the sound of a mobile phone playing "Zindagi har kadam

ek nayi jung hai (Life's every step brings a new battle)". When the news of Monica Devi's positive dope test filtered through, the contingent were glad to be spared early embarrassment at the venue.

There is little time for regrets in a Games where every issue is large scale. Beijing Organising Committee chief Liu Qi told his countrymen that the Olympics were, "the cultural activity that draws the biggest attention from people all over the world... we cannot afford any mistakes". This is the largest influx of foreigners ever allowed willingly into China at a single time. Visas permitting, an estimated 50,000 including athletes, support and technical staff, media and

tourists are expected during the Games.

The state's drive behind Beijing 2008 has been ferocious, consuming a country and its people. Nearly two million cars have been taken off Beijing's roads, and factories shut down to lower pollution levels, not just in the city but in four neighbouring provinces. Estimates of relocations in the run-up to the Games have varied from the Government's official figure of 6,037 families to as many as five lakh. In a searing series on the cost of the Games, *The Strait Times* of Singapore reported that despite 85 percent people hit by drought in Hebei province, water was being diverted from four reservoirs to Beijing to meet the